

German Tanks: 1939-40

Although the Treaty of Versailles in 1919 forbade Germany to own tanks, its army experimented with armored warfare in the Soviet Union during the 1920s. After Hitler came to power in 1933, Germany began openly building armored forces. The first tanks, Panzer I and II, were intended for training, but were used in the Spanish Civil War, which highlighted a number of weaknesses. Panzer IIIs and IVs incorporated these lessons, but they were scarce in 1939. The Panzer II remained the most common German tank throughout this period.



△ Panzer I Ausf A

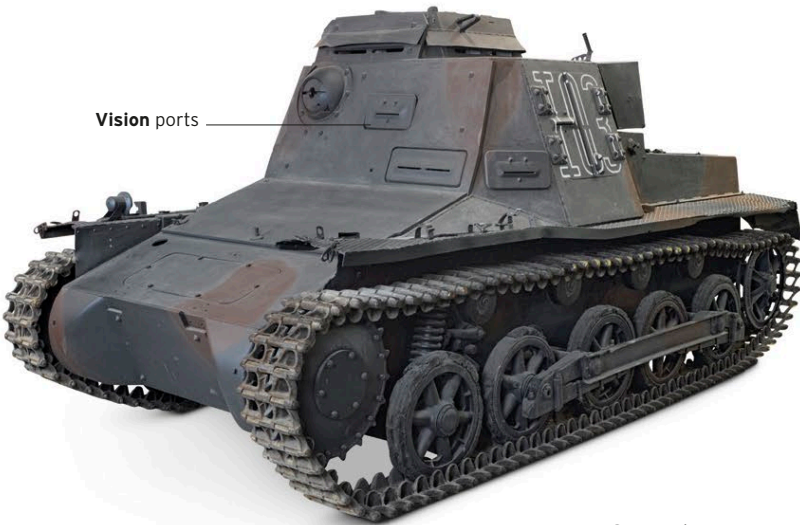
Date 1934 **Country** Germany
Weight 6 tons (5.5 tonnes)
Engine Krupp M305 gasoline, 57 hp
Main armament 2 x 7.92 mm MG13 machine guns

The Panzer I was intended only as a training vehicle. However, a shortage of other tanks meant the two-man Panzer I would ultimately see combat in Spain, Poland, France, Denmark, Norway, Russia, and North Africa. This Ausf A variant was underpowered and not really viable in combat; it proved invaluable for training, however.

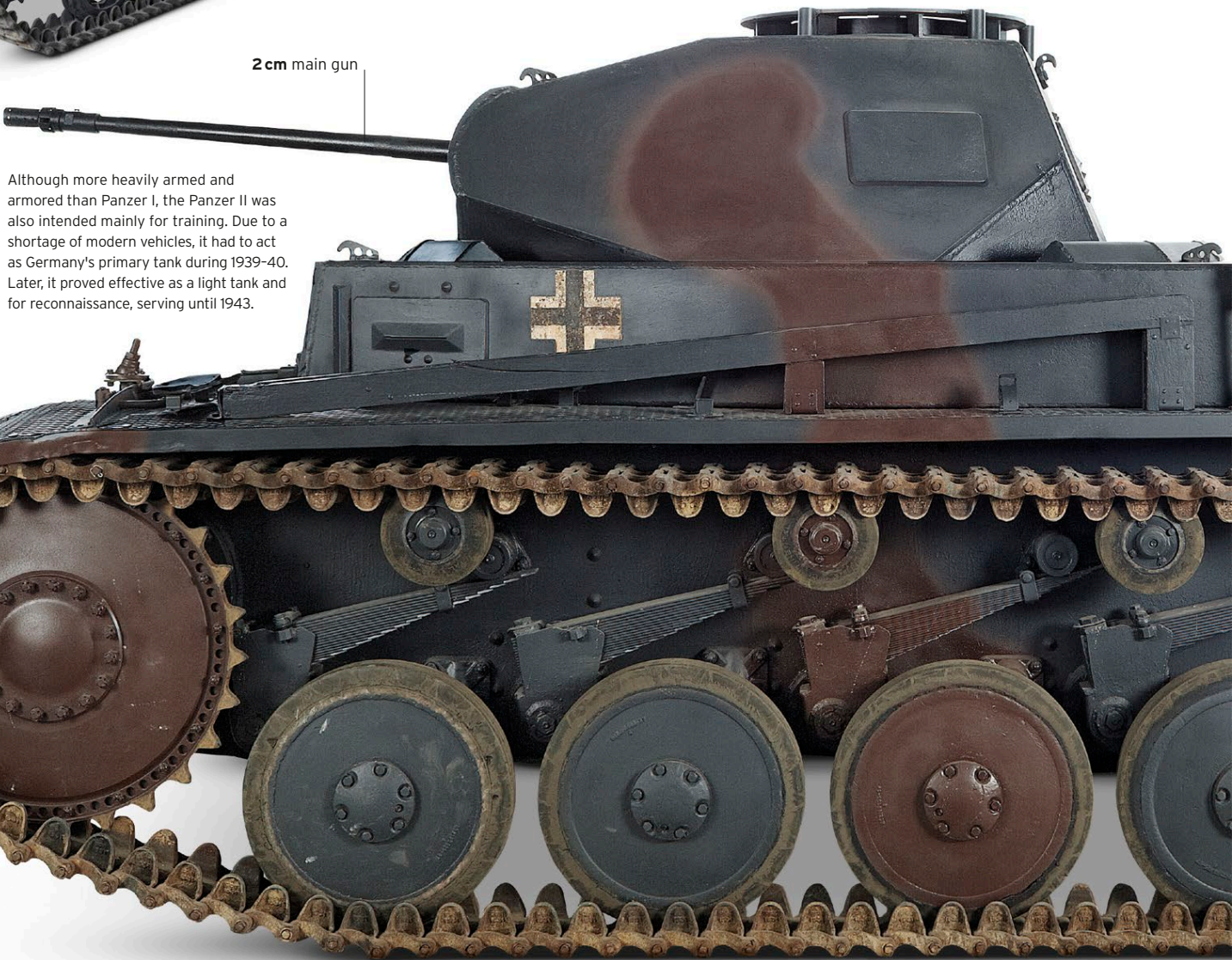
◁ Panzer I Command Tank

Date 1935 **Country** Germany
Weight 6.6 tons (6 tonnes)
Engine Maybach NL38TR gasoline, 100 hp
Main armament 7.92 mm MG34 machine gun

The standard Panzer I only had space for a radio receiver, but unit commanders needed to transmit as well. This vehicle carried a transmitter and a third seat for the radio operator. It was used from 1935 until late 1942, when it was replaced by more advanced vehicles.



Vision ports



2 cm main gun

▷ Panzer II

Date 1937 **Country** Germany
Weight 10.6 tons (9.7 tonnes)
Engine Maybach HL62TR gasoline, 140 hp
Main armament 2 cm KwK 30 L/55 cannon

Although more heavily armed and armored than Panzer I, the Panzer II was also intended mainly for training. Due to a shortage of modern vehicles, it had to act as Germany's primary tank during 1939-40. Later, it proved effective as a light tank and for reconnaissance, serving until 1943.

Drive sprocket at front